🏹 Absurd Collective Nouns: Medieval "Terms of Venery"

Official 16-Question Master Quiz & Historical Etymology Key • Dame Juliana Berners (1486)

MASTER ANSWER KEY

The Venery Tradition: In 1486, Dame Juliana Berners printed *The Book of Saint Albans*, introducing aristocratic hunting ("venery") group nouns. Designed as witty courtly tests of gentlemanly education, these poetic terms characterized animals by sound, behavior, temperament, or medieval superstition. Today, many remain fully accepted English idioms.

🐓 AERIAL & BIRDS
- Crows: **A Murder**
- Owls: **A Parliament**
- Ravens: **An Unkindness**
- Flamingos: **A Flamboyance**

🦁 HEAVY BEASTS
- Rhinos: **A Crash**
- Hippos: **A Bloat**
- Hyenas: **A Cackle**
- Lions: **A Pride**

🐿️ WITTY & SOCIAL
- Ferrets: **A Business**
- Lemurs: **A Conspiracy**
- Apes: **A Shrewdness**
- Pandas: **An Embarrassment**

🦔 CURIOSITIES
- Porcupines: **A Prickle**
- Giraffes: **A Tower**
- Peacocks: **An Ostentation**
- Wombats: **A Wisdom**

Q1 • 🐓 CROWS — **A Murder of Crows**

In 15th-century hunting lore, what is the official collective noun for crows?

A) cartel	✓ **B) murder**
C) gossip	D) conspiracy

Lore: Originating in *The Book of Saint Albans*, scavengers were linked to battlefields and portents of death in medieval folklore.

Q2 • 🦉 OWLS — **A Parliament of Owls**

If you stumble upon a midnight gathering of owls in woodland, you see a...

✓ **A) parliament**	B) council
C) senate	D) synod

Lore: Inspired by C.S. Lewis and medieval myth viewing owls as solemn, wise lawmakers debating grave matters under moonlight.

Q3 • 🐦‍⬛ RAVENS — **An Unkindness of Ravens**

What is the classic collective term for ravens, dating back to 1486?

A) treachery	✓ **B) unkindness**
C) malice	D) darkness

Lore: Peasant myth alleged ravens were unnatural parents who evicted fledglings prematurely to scavenge alone.

Q4 • 🦩 FLAMINGOS — **A Flamboyance of Flamingos**

When hundreds of pink flamingos wade together, English officially calls them a...

A) carnival	✓ **B) flamboyance**
C) masquerade	D) dazzle

Lore: From French *flamboyant* (flaming/vibrant), describing their iridescent pink plumes and synchronous courtship dances.

Q5 • 🦏 RHINOCEROSES — **A Crash of Rhinos**

A heavy-armored group of rhinoceroses running together is termed a...

A) smash	✓ **B) crash**
C) thunder	D) battering

Lore: Near-blind, 2-tonne rhinos gallop at 50 km/h, literally crashing headlong through brush and savanna woodland without stopping.

Q6 • 🦛 HIPPOPOTAMUSES — **A Bloat of Hippos**

A herd of hippopotamuses wallowing in a riverbank is poetically known as a...

✓ **A) bloat**	B) bulk
C) basin	D) barrel

Lore: Directly depicts their rotund, barrel-like bloated silhouettes basking in murky African river waters.

Q7 • 🐕 HYENAS — **A Cackle of Hyenas**

A pack of spotted hyenas prowling the savanna is officially called a...

A) giggle	✓ **B) cackle**
C) sneer	D) scoff

Lore: Coined after their shrill, maniacal high-pitched vocalizations echoing across plains during communal feeding bouts.

Q8 • 🐼 PANDAS — **An Embarrassment of Pandas**

What endearing collective noun describes a group of giant pandas?

A) tumble	✓ **B) embarrassment**
C) nap	D) bamboozle

Lore: Celebrates their notoriously clumsy somersaults, playful bumbling nature, and awkward physical antics.

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Official 16-Question Master Quiz & Historical Etymology Key (Continued)

MASTER ANSWER KEY

Q9 • 🦡 FERRETS — **A Business of Ferrets**

If you keep multiple pet ferrets together in an enclosure, you own a...

A) mischief	✓ **B) business**
C) hustle	D) scramble

Lore: Originates from Middle English *besynes* ("restless busyness"), portraying their relentless darting and scurrying.

Q10 • 🐒 LEMURS — **A Conspiracy of Lemurs**

A troop of ring-tailed lemurs huddled together in Madagascar is a...

✓ **A) conspiracy**	B) syndicate
C) secret	D) whisper

Lore: Their wide luminous tapetum eyes and secretive jungle circle huddles evoked cloaked conspirators hatching midnight treason.

Q11 • 🦔 PORCUPINES — **A Prickle of Porcupines**

What is the unmistakably descriptive group name for porcupines?

A) needle	✓ **B) prickle**
C) barb	D) quill

Lore: An onomatopoeic visual gem directly invoking their bristling coat of 30,000 defensive barbed quills when startled.

Q12 • 🦒 GIRAFFES — **A Tower of Giraffes**

What architectural term describes a tall group of giraffes walking?

A) steeple	✓ **B) tower**
C) monument	D) column

Lore: Standing up to 5.8m tall, a migrating family silhouettes against the flat grassland horizon like walking watchtowers.

Q13 • 🦚 PEACOCKS — **An Ostentation of Peacocks**

When male peacocks strut displaying their iridescent train, they form an...

A) extravagance	✓ **B) ostentation**
C) arrogance	D) elegance

Lore: From Latin *ostentare* ("to flaunt/show off"), mocking the peacock's shameless vanity and pompous display.

Q14 • 🦍 APES — **A Shrewdness of Apes**

Medieval hunters in 1486 granted a group of apes which cunning collective noun?

A) cunning	✓ **B) shrewdness**
C) wisdom	D) mischief

Lore: In 15th-century English, 'shrewd' meant playfully mischievous or calculatingly cunning, praising their quick wits.

Q15 • 🦁 LIONS — **A Pride of Lions**

Which venery term became completely mainstream in everyday modern English?

A) reign	✓ **B) pride**
C) majesty	D) dominion

Lore: Medieval heraldry crowned the lion king of beasts; their regal bearing and family loyalty cemented "pride" into standard speech.

Q16 • 🐻 WOMBATS — **A Wisdom of Wombats**

What philosophical collective noun is reserved for Australia's wombats?

A) ponder	✓ **B) wisdom**
C) contemplation	D) trundle

Lore: Despite their slow, stocky waddle, observers bestowed this dignified title honoring their ancient, unbothered stoicism.

🏆 OFFICIAL MEDIEVAL VENERY RANKING SYSTEM

BASED ON 16 DIAGNOSTIC ITEMS

- 👑 **15–16 Correct** — Grandmaster of the Royal Hunt (Dame Juliana's Chosen Scholar)
- 🏹 **12–14 Correct** — Chief Falconer of the English Realm (Courtly Lore Expert)
- 🐂 **8–11 Correct** — Knowledgeable Forest Squire (Competent Field Navigator)
- 🪿 **0–7 Correct** — Confused Peasant Wandering in Sherwood Forest